



How to Build an Impactful High Holiday Sermon

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Gearing Up

AN INTERVIEW WITH RABBI SHAIS TAUB

Q: When standing at the pulpit in front of my largest and most varied audience of the year, I would love to convey some of the deep truths of Chassidus. How do I make Chassidus practical?

A: We don't make Chassidus practical. Chassidus is inherently practical. Part of the process of learning Chassidus is to see the practicality within it.

There are two styles of learning: *hafshatah* and *halbashah*. We can learn about *sefiros elyonos* to understand human nature, or we can study human nature to understand *sefiros elyonos*. You've probably noticed the expression of מְשָׁלִים אֶחָדָה אֶחָדָה (Iyov 19:26) in almost every maamar.

When you study something and try to discover its archetype, how it exists on the highest level of spiritual truth, that's called

hafshatah. When you study the same subject and try to see how it manifests in day-to-day life, that's called *halbashah*. We have to do both.

If you properly study a sugya in Chassidus, you will have done both *hafshatah* and *halbashah*. And then, when you will communicate the said concept, you won't have to work on making it practical; you will already see how it is practical.

Q: True point. But how do we communicate the practicality?

A: We're talking about communicating one truth on multiple levels. In the maamar *Taglachas Hametzorah* in *Derech Mitzvosecha*, the Tzemach Tzedek states that Shlomo Hamelech had 3,000 meshalim with which to illustrate a concept and Rabbi Meir had 300 meshalim. What does it mean to have 3,000 meshalim?

A mashal bridges the gap between the familiar and the unfamiliar by comparing something unfamiliar to that which is familiar. By speaking in meshalim, Shlomo Hamelech was able to discuss a concept that was 3,000 levels deeper than the average person was able to understand. He used one mashal to bridge the gap from the 3,000th level to the 2,999th level, and then another mashal to bridge the gap from the 2,999th level to the 2,998th, etc.

Metaphor, classically, is the most powerful tool of a sermon because a metaphor allows you to speak about the unfamiliar in terms that are familiar. Think about the most famous preacher in Jewish history, the Maggid of Dubno. He was famous for his metaphors. In Chassidus, we also use metaphor as a way of talking about things that would otherwise be too abstract or too deep.

In *Igros Kodesh* (vol. 15 § 5,543), the Rebbe responds to Rabbi Avrohom Chanoch Glitsenstein, who asks why there are not that many meshalim in Chabad Chassidus. The Rebbe explains that when the Rebbe presents a mashal, he is not merely comparing one thing to another to help you understand it

better. Rather, the Rebbe is speaking about one concept as it exists on two levels of hishtalshelus. What that means to us is that when we speak in parables, we have to remember that the osios we are using are just a lower-level manifestation of a higher spiritual concept.

When we speak about current events or tell a story of contemporary people and their lives or refer to modern ideas in science, we have to remember that we are using that as a medium through which to speak of a higher spiritual concept on a more relatable level. However, we cannot lose sight of the goal. Our goal is to communicate a deeper spiritual truth.

Q: It sounds like you're saying that even when we use familiar terms or concepts, we need to stay true to the ideas of Chassidus. Can you please elaborate on the process of finding those osios?

A: The Frierdiker Rebbe says that when the Alter Rebbe went to Mezritch, one of the first things he learned from the talmidei haMagid was that a story from the Rebbe is Torah Shebichsav, and a Torah from the Rebbe—a concept the Rebbe explained—is Torah Shebaal Peh. The Frierdiker Rebbe expanded upon this and referred to the idea that Torah Shebichsav is chochmah and Torah Shebaal Peh is binah—chochmah is the information in a hyper-condensed format, whereas binah brings out the details of the original idea. As such, a Chassidishe maaseh is chochmah and a Chassidishe Torah is binah.

The Frierdiker Rebbe then brings the idea from Sefer Yetzirah of “חכים בבניה ומבין בחכמה.” Use chochmah in your binah and binah in your chochmah. As such, in order to explain a concept, you have to find a story that relates to it—which is חכים בבניה—and, conversely, while relating a Chassidishe maaseh, you have to figure out which teaching of Chassidus this story embodies—which is מבין בחכמה.

The easiest way to get people's attention is through a story. Unfortunately, we may end up simply using story after story as a lazy way to keep our audience's attention. Let's not be lazy. When telling a story, let's tell it *because* of the concept that is behind it. As such, when we learn a concept in Chassidus we should ask ourselves what story illustrates this inyan in Chassidus; when we hear a story, we should try to figure out what Chassidic concept this story embodies.

Q: Do you know of any *hadrachah* from the Rebbe regarding what topics shlichim should speak about, specifically on the High Holidays?

A: Great question! In a michtav klali from Yemai Haslichos 5723 (*Igros Kodesh* v. 22 § 8,679), the Rebbe mentions that many Jewish leaders waste the most powerful 48 hours of the year by talking about “הויכח פראבלעמען וועלט-פראבלעמען.” The Rebbe writes that, on the contrary, Rosh Hashanah is about the avodah of the individual. Rosh Hashanah does not just mark the beginning of the world, but the creation of Adam Harishon, an individual person. If you are communal leader, writes the Rebbe, your focus on Rosh



Hashanah should not be on global issues and politics—which provides people an excuse not to look into their own behavior—but on personal avodah.

seems will be a highly contentious presidential election. You can use a contemporary issue as a mashal but be extra careful not to do so in any way that would be considered taking sides. If you're not sure, leave it out. It's not worth it if you turn off even one person.

Q: You make a good point but the fact is that it is challenging to find common ground regarding personal avodah that appeals to my largest and most diverse crowd.

A: If you want to use current events or contemporary topics as meshalim, firstly, you must take care not to get distracted by the mashal. After all, the nimshal is the point. Secondly, remember that the *olam* is a *golam* (the masses are not so bright). You know what you meant but do you know what your audience took away? It is possible that you were trying to communicate a *nekudah* but they didn't hear it. They may have just heard the mashal. If you're going to use big issues as your mashal, take care that what you are serving does not end up like the plate of the three-year-old at a birthday party who eats all the frosting on the cake but not the cake itself.

As an aside, it is important to note that it is not a shliach's place to use his sermons to make political statements. This is even more important to remember this year—for shluchim living in the United States, for whom Rosh Hashanah falls out in the heat of what

Q: So how do I practically go about preparing a sermon that will reach everyone?

A: Start learning after Tisha b'Av. As you learn, try to find one *nekudah* in Chassidus that speaks to you, be it from a maamar, a sicha, or a letter from the Rebbe. A *michtav klali* can serve as an incredible resource. Farbreng with yourself about that *nekudah* until Rosh Hashanah and then communicate it in your sermon. One point per sermon. That's it. *כל יתר כנטול דמי* (*Chulin* 58b). Less is more.

In the month that you've been farbrenging with yourself, you will have unpacked the osios with which to give it over, be it through stories, meshalim, or even jokes. Remember, though, that you're not a comedian. Don't tell a joke for the sake of a joke. After all, *klipas noga* for its own sake becomes *ra gomur* (*Likutei Amarim* ch. 7). You might argue that the joke is not just for its own sake—it's for the sake of loosening up the crowd. Just remember that if your joke isn't consistent with your topic, you will have distracted your audience and pointed them in the wrong direction. If you tell a joke, it has to be another facet of *binah* from the *nekudas hechochmah* that you're trying to convey.

If you've really done it properly, by the time you've finished farbrenging you probably won't even need to write out the whole sermon. You will just need a card with cues and keyword reminders. You won't have to write the filler of how to put them together because the original point will be so clear to you.

Remember what you have that nobody else has. You might have a beautiful building, an attractive kiddush, a professional children's program—or you might not. Either way, other people have that, too. What you have that is unique to you as a shliach are the messages that touch the neshamos of this generation. Nobody else has it. Don't squander the time to try to be the most entertaining or inspiring sermon in town. Your goal is not

to wow people or blow them away. Your goal is to communicate with clarity and precision some truth that will stick with the people, a truth that they won't be able to shake loose even years from now.

Q: That all sounds good and fine but I simply am not an orator. What should I do?

A: You don't have to be an orator. You just have to say something of substance and you have to mean it. Just find something that the Rebbe said, figure out what it means to you, and share it with your crowd.

Also, you don't have to say it *besha'im omro*. As far as your audience is concerned, you are Chabad, and if you say it, it represents Chabad. *Shluchos shel odom kemoso*. Just say it.

Q: My crowd includes people spanning a variety of levels of observance. How do I ensure that my sermon applies to everyone?

A: If you get too specific, you may say things that don't apply to everyone. However, if you leave things more general, your words will apply to everyone. For example, this year, 5776, marks 40 years since the Rebbe launched *miytzva chinuch*. Let's say you were speaking about the importance of providing Jewish children with a Jewish education, your remarks would mean something different to each person. Whether it's the person who's just come

in for the first time and might need to hear that you have a Hebrew school, or the person who's been coming for fifteen years and needs to be encouraged to switch his children from public school to day school, or the person whose child is in day school and needs to be encouraged to switch to yeshiva, leave the practical application to each person.

You can even say, "If you'd like to discuss how to apply this in your personal situation, please come see me after yom tov. My door is open." To be sure, no other rabbi offers this in his High Holiday speech. By doing so, in addition to setting yourself apart in a very positive way, you are making it clear that the whole purpose of a High Holiday sermon is *hamaaseh hu ha'ikar* and *talmud hameivi li'day maaseh*. The ultimate purpose of a Tishrei is *v'yaakov holach ledarko*. Thirdly, your remark implies in a very positive way that you hope to see them all year long and not just for the High Holidays.

Q: When is the best time to deliver the sermon?

A: If everything goes perfectly, we try to arrange things such that our biggest crowd will be there for tekios. Make that the time for your big sermon, as well. If you choose to speak at other points during davening, do so quickly so as not to disrupt the flow. Present 60-second sound bytes that are purely informational. Think of yourself as narrating a tour of the machzor. You don't necessarily need to be inspirational at those times.

Q: I find it challenging to prepare my sermon each week and certainly cannot spend six weeks working on each one. How can I apply any of these tips when preparing my weekly sermon?

A: You can buy a drosha. But what you might be even happier doing is using those droshas as training wheels. Figure out what the authors are doing that you like and then do it too, albeit in your own style.

Shluchim can also come together in groups of friends via WhatsApp and, on motzoei Shabbos, suggest a topic that they've thought of. Throughout the week, the shluchim will suggest stories, jokes, etc. By erev Shabbos, you'll have been farbrenging about the said topic all week and on Shabbos each shliach will present it in his own way. Not only does this system divide up the work, but the whole is greater than the sum of the parts (*Gemara Sotah* 34a).

The Process

How to Turn Lofty Chassidic Concepts Into Relatable, Impactful Sermons

The example that follows demonstrate how lofty Chassidic concepts can be presented to any audience in simple, relevant terms, providing inspiration and a takeaway message for everyday living.

BY RABBI SHAIS TAUB



Can you please demonstrate how lofty words or concepts in Chassidus speak to daily living, such as ליל ר"ה עלית המלכות תקיעת שופר בנין המלכות?

Here's an example: *What does it mean when we say that the world is behis'alfus, in a state of semi-consciousness, on erev Rosh Hashanah? What does it mean when we say that שנה עיני ה' אלוך בה מראשית השנה ועד אחרית שנה means that Hashem enlivens the world one year at a time? What does it mean that without drawing down Hashem's rotzon to be melech the world will disappear?*

This is an abstract concept because the average person doesn't feel it. I don't become tired on erev Rosh Hashanah. The sky doesn't become dim on erev Rosh Hashanah.

One way to draw down this concept and connect it to everyday living is via a moshol, such as the one that follows.

Have you ever been in this situation? You've been trying to reach an important person for a very long time. When the person finally calls you back, you are driving and you realized that your cell phone battery is all too close to shutting down. You've forgotten your charger at home. You're sitting at a red light. You can't interrupt the person on the other end of the line and say, "Sorry, I am an irresponsible person and don't keep my phone charged and my phone is about to cut off so can you please call me back in half an hour."

As such, you act totally calm while racing home as quickly as you can. You dash out of the car, leaving the doors wide open, and run into the kitchen where your charger has been faithfully waiting for you, plugged into the wall near the toaster. You manage to plug in your phone one second before the phone is about to shut down... completely unbeknownst to the person on the other end of the line. He has no idea that the conversation was one second away from being cut off.

That's erev Rosh Hashanah. Hashem charges the batteries of the universe with one year's worth of life. On erev Rosh Hashanah, those in the know dash home to plug in and recharge. Those who are not in the know have no idea that the call is about to be dropped.



Can you please explain your thinking process, i.e., how you took this concept and figured out how to draw it to the practical? I'd like to be able to apply this thought process to other areas of Chassidus.

I'll make a confession: I'm not such a responsible adult who always makes sure his phone is charged. I've actually been in that situation—I know that feeling. But I think what you're asking is how do I get from *binyan hamalchus* to plugging in a phone charger?

In *Hayom Yom* (20 Tammuz), the Rebbe writes that there are three types of hisbonenus. There is *hisbonenus limudis*. This is not study. It is contemplation and connection to the ideas contained within the text at hand—understanding the meaning of these ideas. Then there is *hisbonenus far'n davenen*. Following the first type of *hisbonenus*, a person connects to the chayus of the idea, the feelings behind these ideas. Finally, there is *hisbonenus in davenen*. This is the ultimate level, where one tries to connect with the G-dliness of the idea. This is a very hard level to communicate and is probably one that a person can really only experience in davening itself. The second level is one that you should be able to give over.

So, I learn a concept: *The world is behis'alfus and needs new koach to keep it going. Tekias shofar draws down energy for the entire year.*

Now that I understand what the concept *means*, I need to figure out how it *feels*. I'm not Hashem—I can't relate

to how it feels for Him—but how can I relate to the emotion behind this concept? How might it feel? Perhaps like a lot of suspense, tension. Then I ask myself, “When have I ever felt this way?”

I try to think of an example that includes more than one person—one of whom is unaware of the suspense. The mashal also needs to include the urgency for one party to complete an action—he cannot simply be a passive victim—and he must do it by a certain time. And then I ask myself, “When have I had these feelings under these conditions?” And I come up with a simple example that everyone can relate to—the cell phone charger!

It doesn't always work. Like with any creative process, you can't be afraid to miss. By the time I use a moshol in a lecture, I've probably been using it in my day-to-day conversation for months. If you keep on trying out different osios and keep on tweaking the details of your meshalim, you will always be prepared to speak—you've been constantly farbrenging about these nekudos for months.



What steps would you take to develop this into an exciting sermon?

The moshol of the phone charger is a cute moshol. But it's not stirring. It lacks a certain gravity. I would use it as an element in my sermon but a sermon cannot be based on it.

I need to find another parallel. Maybe I have another moshol for the same concept. Now I will try to search for a moshol, where the moshol itself depicts a serious situation, something people will recognize as being poignant.

There's a couple who've come to a point in their marriage where the emotional currency has completely been depleted. They are still living under one roof and, as far as the neighbors and kids know, they are still married. On an emotional level, though, the relationship has run out of every last ounce of trust and love. They are on the brink of divorce. In fact, they are in the car on the way to write a get. At the last moment, the husband says to the wife, "I don't know how you feel. I know that we don't have a lot to base our future on, but I say that I am ready to dedicate myself again to this marriage. Whatever you say is your decision but as for me, I am ready." She turns to him and says, "I am ready too." At that moment, that marriage that was a hollow shell becomes infused with enough energy to take on new life. So, too, because of His desire to have a partnership with us, Hashem enlivens the universe with a year's worth of energy at a time. On the last day of the year, all that energy is gone. Hashem says to us, "I want you—do you want me?" Tekias shofar is our answer to Hashem that yes, we do want Him. And Hashem says, "If so, I have the desire to create an entire universe for another year."

This marriage moshol is more than a moshol—it's a theme. It's a theme about when the passion and energy and trust is gone, and how to get it back. Everyone can relate to this.

Everyone has some endeavor that they were passionate about that has lost its luster. If nothing is done, the default is that it will disappear. What is the turning point at the last moment that helps the marriage regain its energy? Willingness. Even when we have nothing upon which to base our commitment,

if there's willingness, we can build anew. That's what a new year means. You've gone through a lot and, on a rational level, you're done. However, if you have willingness, that's powerful and can infuse your situation with brand new life.

I can come up with many more ways to say the same thing. If this were a farbrengen, we could farbreng on this nekuda until 5:00 a.m. But this is a 30-minute speech. I want to make sure that while I still have 5-10 minutes left, I clearly connect to maaseh bepoel. In addition to hachlotos that they can take on, I want to give the people an action that they can do right here and now. This will be a hachlata they can follow through on in the next 10 minutes—it's a kavana to have during tekias shofar.

I don't need my sermon to be the most memorable part of yom tov. When I'm speaking, I'm being active and my congregation is being mostly passive. What I really want, though, is to empower them and lead them to be participants. My drosha is a successful one if it is simply a hachanah for tekias shofar, where the people can feel actively involved through their personal meditation.

We're about to begin tekias shofar. We're about to have the opportunity to infuse new vigor into a world on it's last breath. I want each of you to think about this on a personal level. I want you to think about a situation that you think is hopeless—irredeemable—and realize that even at the last second, when the battery symbol is flashing, you can plug the charger back into the wall... that on the way to write the divorce, you can renew the vows. All you need is willingness.

I want you to think during tekios that you are speaking one-on-one with Hashem. You are the only person in the shul right now. You might have complaints and you might have issues and many good reasons why you cannot stay in this relationship anymore. However, at this moment all Hashem is asking you is one question: "I want you, do you want me." It's a yes or no question. "Do you have the willingness to continue?" All you have to do is answer "yes" and all the energy we need to continue another year will immediately rush into the world and into our lives.



Ingredients for a Successful Sermon

BASED ON AN INTERVIEW WITH RABBI SIMON JACOBSON

Whether it's a wintery Shabbos morning or the eve of Kol Nidrei, a successful sermon will contain the following components.

- **ONE THEME:** כל המוסיף גורע. Focus on a single theme, which should serve as the thread that connects everything you speak about. Example: Why do we celebrate Rosh Hashanah?

STRUCTURE:

- **A HOOK:** an opening question, statement, story, or joke to be used as the introduction to your talk to draw in and intrigue your audience. Example: I read yesterday that there are 75 trillion cells in the human body.
- **A “MIDDLE”:** The meat of your sermon. This segment should include a stimulating thought related to the parsha or holiday. Use a provocative question on a verse or theme of the holiday.
- **A CONCLUSION:** Wrap up your talk with a short and poignant takeaway message, including a practical example of its application. Even the deepest Chassidic concepts can be applied to everyday living (see previous pages for more on how to do this). Example: I suggest that every night, before we put our children to sleep, we should share the following thought with them....

CRITICAL ELEMENTS FOR THE SERMON TO BE EFFECTIVE:

- **RELEVANCE:** Nothing is more important to reach your audience

than relevance. Know before whom you are speaking and what their concerns are. To engage your audience, they must feel that you understand and identify with them. Identify a problem or issue people are struggling with and address it directly. Whether it's relationships, love, pain, or any other element of the human condition, your goal is to add value to something that is already pertinent to your audience. If you can't express the relevance, don't say it. Example: Relevant: Rosh Hashanah is a day of hope to correct past mistakes. (Abstract and irrelevant: It's a day of teshuva—40 days after the sin of the Golden Calf; Moshe got the Jews to be forgiven.)

- **COMPASSION:** Demonstrate your care and empathy to a given situation or challenge. Remember: people don't care how much you know until they know how much you care. A personal story—that either happened with you or with someone else—is always a great way to convey this.
- **INSPIRATION:** A good sermon is not a class. It's more about inspiration and motivation than information, though good content is necessary as well.
- **YOUR OWN FLAVOR:** דברים היוצאים מן הלב נכנסים אל הלב.
- **SPEAK FROM YOUR HEART.** If you use someone else's speech, customize it and make it your own before delivering it.
- **A HEAPING DOSE OF PASSION:** Deliver the sermon with a sense of urgency, with a determined and passionate voice.
- **A SPRINKLE OF WIT AND HUMOR:** Milsa d'bdichusa relaxes the mind. Be informal, easygoing. However, every joke must have a message. Use only humor that comes naturally to you. Don't force it.
- **REFER TO COMMUNAL EVENTS, E.G., SIMCHA OR TRAGEDY R"l:** This establishes trust and shows people that you relate to them.
- **CATER TO YOUR CROWD'S TASTE:** Example: Intellectual, emotional, etc.
- **KEEP IT SHORT, SWEET, AND SIMPLE TO UNDERSTAND.**

A Sermon in a Nutshell

BY RABBI MANIS FRIEDMAN

- **Take a word or concept and present it as it is conventionally defined.**

Example: זכרנו לחיים. Remember us for life. I don't want to die and the reason I need to beg for life is because I've sinned and don't deserve another year.

- **Turn the subject matter upside down by demonstrating how the conventional definition just doesn't cut it.**

Example: Firstly, the people who don't come to shul don't die. Secondly, I'm healthy. Why should I worry that G-d will strike me? Thirdly, do I really deserve to die just because I don't keep kosher?

- **Share the Chassidic perspective on the matter (which will fill in all the gaps and provide a new outlook).**

Example: זכרנו לחיים means “teach me how to live.” I'm not afraid of dying—I'm afraid of killing another year.

- **Channel the education and inspiration into maaseh b'poel.**

Example: This year, as a community, let's build a mikvah/kosher restaurant/preschool so we can live a life the way G-d wants us to/so we can provide our children with the opportunity to learn how to live the way G-d wants us to.

Two Additional Examples

Following the pattern outlined above, here are brief outlines for a number of High Holiday sermon themes. [Editor's note: See “Ingredients for a Successful Sermon” on previous page for more details on what to include and how to present it.]

1. ROSH HASHANAH היום הרת עולם

Anniversary: the date on which an event took place in a previous year. Traditionally marked by reliving the original experience. Evolutionists are still trying to figure out how the world came to be but on Rosh Hashanah, we think about why the world came to be.

That G-d can create the world is not impressive. What's impressive is that He would bother to do so. On Rosh Hashanah, we ask ourselves, “Is this world giving G-d satisfaction?” If you were G-d, would you keep this mess going?

Like in any good

relationship, if one partner is concerned as to whether the other partner is still interested, he has to let him know. Similarly, on Rosh Hashanah we say, “We don't know whether you want to be our King but we definitely want You.” Let's each take upon ourselves to let G-d know that we want Him.

2. YOM KIPPUR חרטה על העבר, קבלה על העתיד

What is regret? “A feeling of sorrow or remorse for a fault, act, loss, disappointment, etc.” (dictionary.com).

Unhealthy: I regret that I stole. “I'm sorry I did that.” Healthy: I regret that I hurt the person from whom I stole. “I'm sorry I did that to you.”

Reflecting on our relationship with Hashem, it's not that we feel guilty about eating non-kosher—it's that we feel guilty for ruining the relationship.

With the significance of a relationship, you're more likely to keep to your resolution when you know whom you are doing it with or for.... 🇮🇱

Written by Mrs. Elky Raitport

Tips 📖

To Set Yourself Apart

BY RABBI MANIS FRIEDMAN

- Remember that your sermon is a vehicle through which to share an authentic yom tov mood, theme, and experience with your audience. Don't squander it on politics.
- Maintain the high road and don't lower yourself with cheap jokes.
- Share stories and ideas that inspire you personally so that your talk will be genuine.
- Make the goal of your talk to help better the lives of your listeners.